

propositions, and the support from the national or regional governments. And, not to be underestimated, we recognise that the mindset of sustainable smart mobility is increasingly coming to the fore,” Sudarshan Venu, MD of TVS Motor Company, said at the company’s 32nd annual general meeting.

DEFENDING LEGACY

The competition may be snapping at their heels, but India’s top two bike makers, Hero MotoCorp and Honda Motorcycle & Scooter, aren’t sitting idle. They retained their market share, even though both did not make any big-ticket launches this year, thanks to a steady revival in rural demand.

Hero MotoCorp is looking to spread its bets across all segments to maintain its market share. “[Growth] drivers are at the entry segment, where we have a very strong, formidable market share,” Niranjana Gupta, CEO of Hero MotoCorp, said during the Q1 analyst call.

The company will also focus on increasing the market share in the 125 cc segment. Over the years, its share has declined in this segment as competitors raced ahead. But its share jumped from 13% in Q4 to 20% in Q1. “In 125 cc, we had a steep recovery... which is why we’re expanding the category,” Gupta said.

Hero has also set its sights on the electric segment, though it’s a latecomer in this space. It has partnered with Zero Motorcycles, via an investment of \$60 million,

to add electric motorcycles to the Vida range by 2025-26. As the world’s largest two-wheeler manufacturer, Hero MotoCorp’s entry here will undoubtedly accelerate electric adoption. “Hero MotoCorp’s entry could shift the market dynamics, potentially favouring larger, more established companies with the resources to invest,” says Jain of Markets & Markets.

Meanwhile, Honda Motorcycle & Scooter remains undeterred by the competition.

BSA, it is eyeing the neo-classic segment that has been a turf of Royal Enfield. “This is the segment that will grow the fastest,” says Anupam Thareja, Co-founder of Classic Legends. The company plans to add 100 touch points as part of its expansion plans.

As the competition in the 350 cc segment increases, Royal Enfield, which holds a whopping 90% market share, will be focussing on the 350-650 cc segment. “The Indian market is very important for us,” Siddharth Lal, MD of Eicher Mo-

IN INDIA’S HIGHLY COMPETITIVE, EXTREMELY PRICE-SENSITIVE MOTORBIKE MARKET, EVERY SEGMENT HAS ITS OWN LOGIC AND, MOST OFTEN, ITS OWN SET OF COMPETITORS

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“India’s market is versatile [enough] to accommodate all types of powertrains, so there is room for EVs. There is room for flex fuel. There is room for such alternate products coming in,” says Yogesh Mathur, Director of Sales and Marketing at Honda Motorcycle & Scooter India.

BATTLE OF CLASSICS

And, finally, in the premium category, Mahindra & Mahindra is hoping it will be third-time lucky via its two-wheeler foray through Classic Legends. With brands like Jawa, Yezdi, and

tors, said at the company’s 42nd annual general meeting.

The increase in competition, analysts observe, could dent Royal Enfield’s market share slightly. “But Royal Enfield will also try to balance it out by offering more features and trying to retain segments,” says Gupta.

The battle gong has been sounded and it will be a fight to the finish. There is no comfort here for the incumbents as they confront an ever shifting battlefield. Only the brave will remain standing when the dust settles. **BT**

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